

Raconte

Spoken journaling, under development. From pianohouseproject.org

What it is

Raconte (French, “tell!”) is an app for iPhone and Mac for keeping a journal out loud. You press record and talk. The app keeps the recording and, as you speak, writes a transcript beside it on the phone itself. **The recording is what is kept.** The text is a helper: it can be corrected, re-done, or replaced later without touching the audio. Nothing is sent anywhere to make the words appear.

What it is for

Between-session reflection, in the client’s own voice. A few minutes after a hard day, a walk, a thought they want to bring to the next session. The client owns the record: every recording and transcript belongs to them, on their own devices and in their own iCloud. Nothing is shared with anyone, including a therapist, unless the client chooses to share it. There is no clinician view and no one on the other end reading along.

Where your words go

1. **The recording stays on the client’s phone or Mac**, inside the app’s own private folder. Nothing is uploaded to make transcription work.
2. **Transcription happens on the device**, using Apple’s built-in speech recognition. Audio is never sent to a transcription service.
3. **Copies live only in the client’s own iCloud**, so their phone and Mac agree and a lost phone is not a lost journal. There is no Raconte server, no account to create, no analytics, and no third party in the path.
4. **The developer cannot read a client’s entries.** Apple encrypts the iCloud copy in transit and at rest. With Apple’s *Advanced Data Protection* turned on (a setting on the client’s Apple account), Apple itself cannot read it either. Without that setting, Apple holds the keys, as it does for most iCloud data.
5. **Nothing is auto-deleted.** Deleted entries wait thirty days in the trash. A damaged entry is set aside, never destroyed. Every recording and transcript can be exported, complete, as ordinary files the client keeps.

Raconte is not a medical device and makes no HIPAA claim. It is a personal journal a client keeps for themselves. It does not sign Business Associate Agreements, and it is not end-to-end encrypted by the app itself. Treat it as you would a paper journal the client owns.

Our current approach is that Raconte is not...

- ...a therapist portal. There is no clinician login and no shared inbox; the client decides what leaves the app, and how.
- ...an account. Nothing to sign up for; the app uses the iCloud identity already on the device.
- ...in the App Store yet. Raconte is in private testing through Apple’s TestFlight, by invitation. It needs iOS 26 or macOS 26.

All of this is still being shaped. We would value your view on how spoken journaling could work best for the people you know who might use it, and on what a therapist would need to feel comfortable suggesting it.

How Raconte compares

Voice-journal and therapy-adjacent apps a client might use instead. Short answers; full notes and sources are in the survey.

	Where stored	Who else can read it	Audio kept	On-device transcription	Account required	Export	Therapist sharing	HIPAA claim	Price
Raconte	Device + own iCloud	No one; Apple holds keys unless ADP is on	Yes, source of truth	Yes (Apple, iOS 26)	No	Everything: audio, text, checksums, in-app verifier	None built in; client exports and hands over	None	Free; private TestFlight
Day One	Device + vendor cloud	Vendor: no (E2E claimed)	Yes	iOS 26 with Apple Intelligence; else Apple servers	For sync	JSON + media incl. audio; PDF, TXT, CSV	Shared Journals or export	Not stated	Free; \$49.99–\$74.99/yr
Journey	Own Google Drive or vendor cloud	Vendor: no with E2E on; else not stated	Yes, but not transcribed	No; OS dictation only	Yes	ZIP; audio not stated	Export	Not stated	\$49.99/yr
Voicenotes	Vendor cloud (AWS)	Vendor staff (one vetted person); AI providers process notes	Yes	No, cloud	Yes (guest trial)	Per note, audio + text; bulk not stated	Export	Not stated	Free; \$99.99/yr
Otter.ai	Vendor cloud	Staff with consent; trains AI on de-identified data by default	Yes (removable)	No, cloud	Yes	TXT, DOCX, PDF, SRT + audio	Export	Enterprise plan only (BAA)	Free; \$16.99/mo
Reflectly	Vendor cloud	Not stated; shows ads	No audio	No; dictation only	Yes	PDF (paid)	Export	Not stated	\$59.99/yr
Rosebud	Vendor cloud (Google)	AI providers (OpenAI, Anthropic, Groq), anonymised text	Not stated	No, cloud	Yes	Markdown; audio not stated	Weekly summary to share	"HIPAA-aligned"; no BAA to users	Free; \$12.99/mo
Daylio	Device + own iCloud/Drive	Vendor: no	Not stated	Not stated	No	PDF, CSV, backup file; audio not stated	Export	Not stated	Free; premium tiers
Mentalium	Device only	Not stated	Not stated	Yes (offline model)	Not stated	Excel report; audio not stated	Emailed report	Not stated	\$59.99/yr
SimplePractice portal	Vendor cloud	Therapist + practice staff	No client audio	None	Yes	Client export not stated	Shared portal (clinician forms)	Yes; BAA with the clinician	Clinician pays, \$49+/mo
TherapyNotes portal	Vendor cloud	Practice staff, by group	No client audio	None	Yes	Not stated	Shared portal (no journaling)	Yes; BAA in terms of service	Clinician pays, \$69+/mo
Quenza	Vendor cloud	Therapist, per note the client shares	No client audio	None	Yes	Not stated	Shared portal; client chooses per note	BAA on request	Practitioner pays, \$25+/mo
Apple Journal	Device + own iCloud	No one, incl. Apple (E2E)	Yes	Yes	Apple Account for iCloud	PDF, whole-journal file; audio not stated	Export	Not stated	Free with iOS/macOS

Checked 2026-09-08; sources in the repo's survey.md. "Not stated" means the vendor's public pages do not say. Prices are US, at time of checking.

Sharing with a therapist today

Raconte has no sharing feature. A client who wants to bring an entry to session can play it from the phone, or export: *About* → *Archive* → *Export archive*... writes a folder the client keeps, one sub-folder per entry with the audio file, a plain-text *transcript.md*, and a checksum list. The client hands over the whole folder, or one transcript, by whatever channel you both already trust.

Questions and feedback are welcome: pianohouseproject.org · source and documentation: github.com/nicolovejoy/raconte